

INTRODUCTION

School Attendance Problems

- School attendance problems (SAPs) refer to a spectrum ranging from regular school attendance with substantial distress to school dropout (Kearney, 2016).
- SAPs are associated adverse short-term effects (e.g., reduced educational attainment and adverse long-term effects (e.g., higher rates of mental and physical problems)
- Already a pervasive problem, the pandemic nearly doubled the rate of SAPs as an additional 6.5 million were estimated to meet criteria for chronic absenteeism (missing more than 10% of school days; Dee, 2023).
- There are four mechanisms often underlying SAPs: avoiding school because it incites negative emotions (ANA), avoidance of social/evaluative situations (ESE), pursuing tangible rewards outside of school (PTR), and attention seeking behavior (AGB) (Kearney, 2002). The exact mechanisms underlying the post-pandemic increase in SAPs are unknown.

RESEARCH QUESTION & HYPOTHESIS

Research Question

- How have the causes underlying school refusal behavior changed following the COVID-19 pandemic?

Hypothesis

- We hypothesized that each of the four subscales would increase significantly from the pre- to post-pandemic group from both child and parent perspectives.

METHOD

Measures

- Reasons underlying SAPs were measured using the School Refusal Assessment Scale-Revised Parent & Child Reports (SRAS-R-P) (SRAS-R-C). The SRAS-R is a 24-item survey that measures symptom severity of the four functions of school refusal behavior (Kearney, 2002).

Sample

- All participants were children aged 5-17 that had been referred to UNLV's School Refusal Clinic for treatment of school refusal behavior (n = 91).

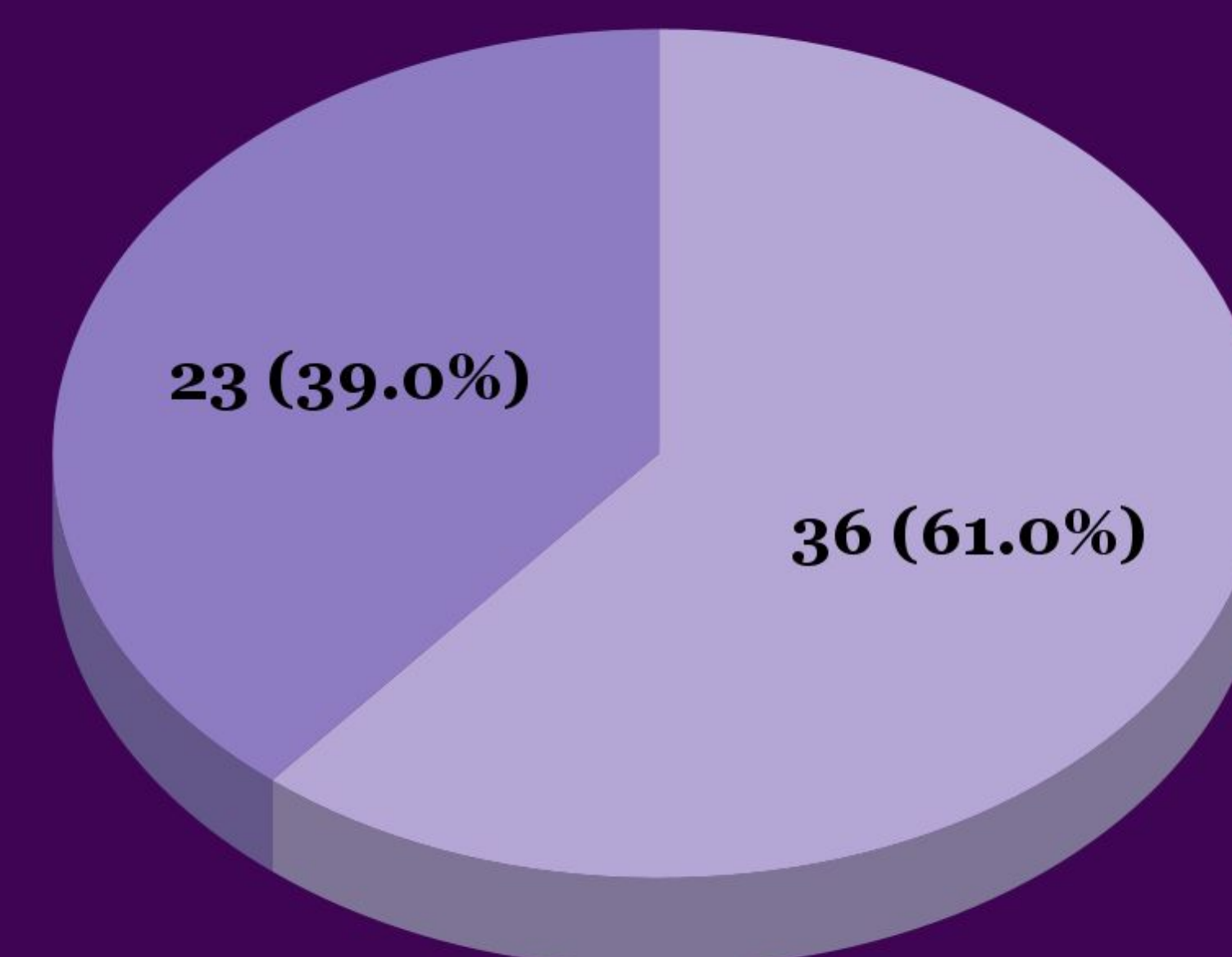
Data Collection & Analyses

- Data were collected during an initial intake appointment at the UNLV School Refusal and Anxiety Disorders Clinic. SRAS-R were respectively filled out by the child and parent. Two independent measure t-tests completed to determine the relationships between school attendance problems and school refusal behavior pre and post pandemic.

PARTICIPANTS

Group 1: Pre-Pandemic

- Girls
- Boys

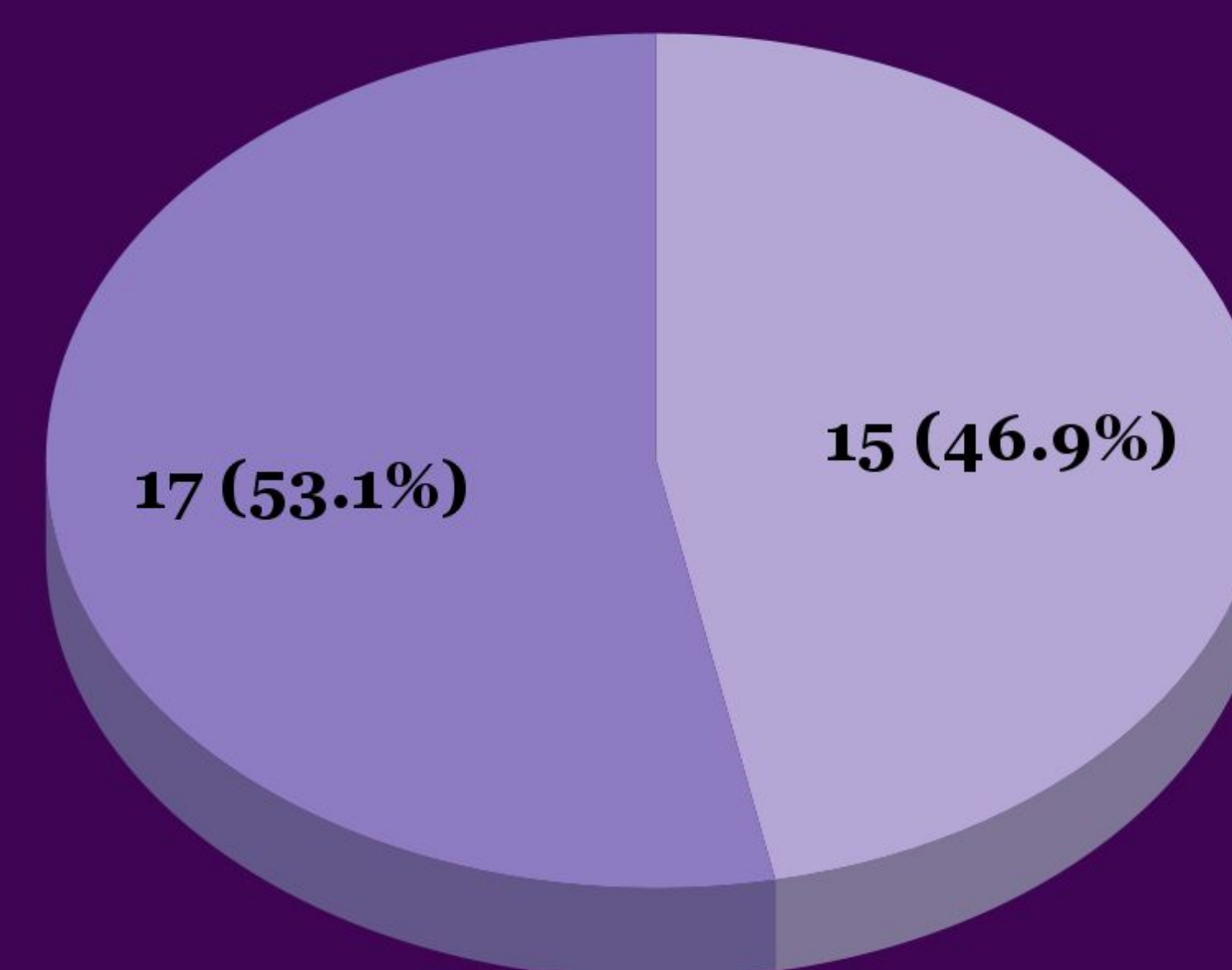


N =
59

A convenience sample of children who had been referred to UNLV's School Refusal clinic prior to the Covid-19 pandemic.

Group 2: Post-Pandemic

- Girls
- Boys



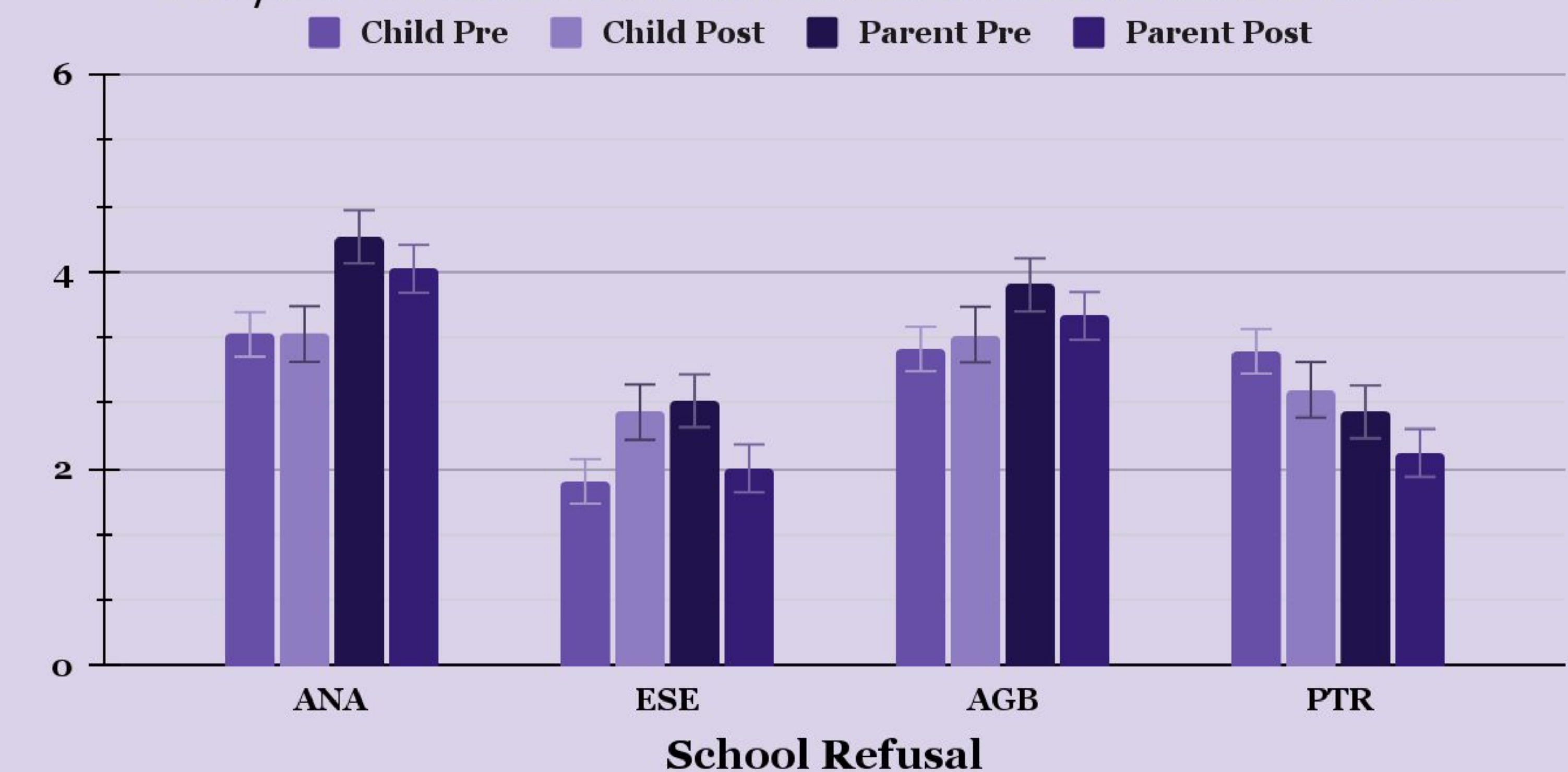
N =
32

A sample of children who had been referred to UNLV's School Refusal following the Covid-19 pandemic.

Between both groups, our study had a total of 91 participants.

RESULTS

Pre/Post Pandemic: Mean School Refusal Scores



- There were no significant differences on the SRAS-C across any of the four subscales (ANA, ESE, AGB, PTR) between the pre- and post-pandemic groups.
- There was a significant difference between on the SRAS-P on the ANA subscale $t(87) = .825, p = .016$.
- Results indicate that parents reported less severity of avoidance of negative affect in the post-pandemic group.

DISCUSSION

Implications

- Our t-tests did not account for extraneous variables and therefore we cannot draw causal conclusions
- Our study suggests that pre- and post-pandemic underlying reasons for school refusal behavior remain fairly consistent, with a small difference in parent ratings.
- Our results suggest differences in parent ratings of ANA, implying that assessing and treating ANA may be beneficial in treating school refusal behavior.

Limitations and Future Directions

- Our study was conducted using a clinical sample, which may affect the generalizability of our results.
- Additionally, due to how recent the Covid-19 pandemic was, our study faced limitations with a smaller sample size for group 2.
- Future research can expand on our results and investigate why ANA had a significant difference.
- Future research can conduct studies on larger sample sizes.

REFERENCES

- Dee, T. S. (2023). Higher Chronic Absenteeism Threatens Academic Recovery from the COVID-19 Pandemic. <https://doi.org/10.31219/osf.io/bfg3p>
- Kearney, C.A. (2002). *Identifying the Function of School Refusal Behavior: A Revision of the School Refusal Assessment Scale*. Journal of Psychopathology and Behavioral Assessment 24, 235-245 (2002). <https://doi.org/10.1023/A:1020774932043>
- Kearney, C. A. (2016). *Managing school absenteeism at multiple tiers: An evidence-based and practical guide for professionals*. New York: Oxford University Press.